



BONUS 4 OF 5 · PRESENTATION

Packaging *That Sells*

Premium kraft boxes with clear windows, compliant allergen labels, natural-light phone photography and full dessert-table setup. The bonus that lets you raise your average ticket 30-40% without baking one extra cookie.

- Premium packaging suite — boxes, cello, ribbons, printable labels
- Legally compliant labels for US Cottage Food, UK/CA/AU home baker laws
- Phone photography with natural light — 4:5 and 1:1 framing rules
- The concrete USD math on ticket increases (from plain to premium)

Fourth bonus of the five

Bonus 4 contents

Chapter 1 · Why packaging is 60% of your perceived value	3
Chapter 2 · The premium packaging kit	5
Chapter 3 · Label design + legal ingredient disclosure	10
Chapter 4 · Natural-light phone photography	14
Chapter 5 · The concrete USD math on ticket increases	18
Chapter 6 · Full dessert-table setup	21
Closing · Your packaging upgrade this month	24

This bonus is the fastest ROI in the entire Cookie Cash Blueprint. A \$12 investment in a kraft box + ribbon + label bumps a \$60 order into an \$85 order in your customer's mind. Same cookies. Better wrapper. The math is real and it's covered here in detail.

CHAPTER 1

Why packaging is 60% of your perceived value

The behavioural science behind why the same cookie in a better box sells for 40% more.

There's a real reason why department-store perfume, luxury watches and premium chocolate spend more on packaging than on the product inside. Perceived value comes from the first thing the buyer sees, not the fifth. In decorated cookies, that first thing is the box.

What your customer actually judges you on

In order:

1. The box exterior (colour, texture, sticker, ribbon)
2. The moment of opening — what's on top when the lid comes off
3. The alignment and spacing of the cookies inside
4. The individual bag / cellophane / label
5. The taste and appearance of the cookie itself

Steps 1-4 all happen before your cookie is in the customer's mouth. If any of them look amateur, the cookie itself now has to fight against a first impression it can't overcome. This is why a mediocre cookie in a premium presentation gets a better review than an outstanding cookie in a plastic ziplock.

THE 15-SECOND RULE

Your customer decides how much they think your order is worth in the first 15 seconds of seeing it. Not after they taste it. Optimise the 15 seconds.

CHAPTER 2

The premium packaging kit

The specific items to buy, priced by size and quantity. Enough to look professional from your very first order.

The base kit (covers 12-cookie standard orders)

ITEM	WHERE	USD PER UNIT	NOTES
Kraft bakery box with clear window, 8x8x2 in (20x20x5 cm)	Uline, Foldabox UK, Amazon	\$0.90-1.40	Bulk 50-pack drops unit cost to \$0.90
Food-grade tissue paper (crinkle-cut)	Amazon, Uline	\$0.05/order	White, pale pink, or match customer's theme
Heat-sealed cellophane bags, 4x6 in	WCS, Amazon	\$0.05 each	Buy 200-pack
Food-safe silica gel packets	Amazon	\$0.20 each	One per 6-8 cookies
Satin ribbon, 3/8 inch wide, 15 colours	Amazon, Michaels	\$0.10/order	3 core colours + seasonal
Custom printed label / sticker (with your logo)	Vistaprint, Sticker Mule, Moo	\$0.08 each	Bulk 500-pack ideal
Thank-you card (business-card size)	Vistaprint, Moo	\$0.05 each	250-pack for \$12

Total packaging cost per 12-cookie order: roughly \$3-4 USD. Customer perceives this as a \$12-15 addition to the value of the order. Net perceived value gain: 3-4x.

Assembly order (do this every time in the same order)

1. Place tissue paper crinkle-cut in the base of the box.
2. Individually bag each cookie, heat-seal, place face-up in the box in a grid.
3. Add silica gel packet(s) tucked to one side, not covering any cookie.
4. Fold the tissue paper over the top of the cookies.
5. Place the thank-you card on top of the folded tissue.
6. Close the box.
7. Tie the ribbon horizontally around the box (single bow, not a wreath — professional cake-shop style).
8. Stick the printed label on the top or one side of the box.

EVERY ONE OF YOUR BOXES SHOULD LOOK IDENTICAL

Your customer takes a photo, posts it, and that photo is your marketing to twenty friends of theirs. If your boxes are consistent (same ribbon colour, same label placement, same tissue tone), your brand snaps into recognition within 4-5 posts. Randomised packaging = no brand recognition.

Label design + legal ingredient disclosure

The compliant label your customer takes home. Requirements vary by country and state — the essentials are covered here.

Cottage Food laws in the US, Home Baker registration in the UK, provincial regulations in Canada, and Class 4 permits in most Australian states all require specific label information. Getting this right protects you legally and looks professional.

3.1 • What every label must include

- **Product name:** "Decorated Sugar Cookie" or "Custom Decorated Cookies"
- **Complete ingredient list** in descending order by weight
- **Allergen statement:** "Contains: wheat, egg, milk" (whatever applies)
- **Made-with-disclosure:** "Made in a kitchen that also handles wheat, egg, dairy, tree nuts" — non-negotiable if any of those are present
- **Best-by date:** "Best within 2 weeks of {date_baked}"
- **Your business name and location:** "Made by {Your Business Name}, {City, State/Country}"

3.2 • Country-specific additions

COUNTRY	ADDITIONAL REQUIREMENT
 USA	Cottage Food law disclaimer: "Made in a home kitchen that is not subject to state inspection." Exact wording varies by state — check your state's Cottage Food page.
 UK	Registered with your local council as a food business (free, mandatory within 28 days of first sale). Full ingredient list with allergens in bold text (14 named allergens per Food Information Regulations).
 Canada	Provincial rules. In most provinces, disclose "prepared in a home kitchen not inspected by a public health inspector."
 Australia	Class 4 food business registration with your local council. FSANZ (Food Standards Australia New Zealand) requires allergen labelling for the 10 mandatory allergens.

3.3 · A sample compliant label

SAMPLE LABEL TEXT

Custom Decorated Sugar Cookies

Ingredients: enriched wheat flour, powdered sugar (sucrose, corn starch), unsalted butter (cream, natural flavouring), pasteurised egg, meringue powder (dried egg white, sugar, cornstarch, gum arabic), pure vanilla extract, gel food colouring, salt.

Contains: wheat, egg, milk.

Made in a kitchen that also handles: wheat, egg, dairy, tree nuts, soy.

Best within 2 weeks of {date_baked}.

Made by **Whitaker Cookie Co.** · {City, State/Country}

{State-specific Cottage Food disclaimer if applicable}

3.4 · Where to print the labels

US/CA: Vistaprint, Moo, Sticker Mule (round or rectangular custom stickers, roughly \$30 for 250 units). **UK:** Moo UK, StickerYou UK, Solopress. **AU:** Moo AU, Vistaprint AU.

Design a template once in Canva (free tier is fine), leave placeholder fields for date and product variant, print in batches of 250. Refresh the design once a year.

THE ONE THING YOU NEVER FAKE ON A LABEL

The allergen statement. If a customer has a serious allergy and your label omits an allergen present in your kitchen, you're exposed to legal liability that a \$60 order will never justify. Over-disclose. Every US/UK/CA/AU label I've seen from professional home bakers reads "may also contain" for wheat, eggs, milk, tree nuts, peanuts and soy, even if the specific batch didn't. Cover yourself.

Natural-light phone photography

The single skill that separates Instagram-worthy from homemade-looking in your customer's DMs.

Every professional cookie photo you've seen on Instagram was taken with a phone by natural window light in the daytime. No studio, no professional camera, no ring light. The three rules below cover 90% of it.

Rule 1 • Only natural light, never overhead kitchen lights

Kitchen fluorescents and warm-white bulbs cast a yellow tint that makes white icing look creamy and pink icing look orange. Move the cookies to a window between 10am and 4pm. Diffused daylight (cloudy day is ideal, or through sheer curtains on a sunny day) gives the cleanest colour rendition.

Rule 2 • Neutral background, minimal props

White marble contact paper (\$8 for a 4-foot roll), off-white foam board (\$4), or a plain wooden cutting board are the three backgrounds that flatter every colour palette. Avoid busy patterned tablecloths, wood grain with strong colour variation, or bright competing colours. The cookie is the subject; everything else is negative space.

Rule 3 • Two framing formats — 4:5 vertical and 1:1 square

- **4:5 vertical (portrait):** Instagram feed default. Take the photo directly overhead of a grid of 6-9 cookies laid flat.
- **1:1 square:** Instagram grid tile. Same overhead shot, tighter crop, room for text overlay if you're posting a product photo with pricing.

Shoot both formats of every finished order. That's your entire content calendar for the week.

Editing — three sliders only

In Instagram, Snapseed, or Lightroom Mobile, adjust these three sliders and nothing else:

1. **Exposure / Brightness:** +5 to +15. Home kitchen photos are almost always slightly underexposed.
2. **White balance / Temperature:** -5 to -10 (cooler). Removes any residual yellow from indoor light.
3. **Contrast:** +5 to +10. Makes white icing pop against neutral backgrounds.

Do not use saturation, vibrance, or filter presets. Those flatten the subtle colour range of royal icing and make everything look artificial.

THE 15-PHOTO PORTFOLIO TARGET

By your fifteenth paid order, you should have 15 professional-quality photos. Post them on a dedicated Instagram grid. This is what turns curious visitors into customers and lets you finally list on Etsy (Bonus 1 mentions Etsy needs 15+ photos).

CHAPTER 5

The concrete USD math on ticket increases

Real numbers on how much more you can charge for the same cookie with each level of packaging upgrade.

Same 12-cookie order. Different presentations. Different acceptable prices.

PRESENTATION TIER	WHAT'S IN IT	PACKAGING COST	ACCEPTABLE RETAIL PER COOKIE	ORDER TOTAL
Level 0 · Plain	Ziplock bag, no label, no box	\$0.50	\$4.50	\$54
Level 1 · Basic	Cellophane bags, plain white bakery box, label	\$1.80	\$6.00	\$72
Level 2 · Premium (recommended)	Kraft box with window, tissue, silica, custom label, ribbon, thank-you card	\$3.50	\$8.00	\$96
Level 3 · Luxury	Level 2 + magnetic-closure box, custom insert, wax-sealed personal note	\$8.00	\$11.50	\$138

The jump from Level 0 to Level 2 costs you \$3 more in packaging and lets you charge \$42 more retail. That's a **13x return on the packaging investment**. This is why packaging is the highest-ROI single upgrade in the entire business.

YEARLY IMPACT OF UPGRADING LEVEL 0 → LEVEL 2

+\$4,200 to +\$8,400 USD/year

At 100-200 orders/year (a realistic Tier 2 baker's pace), the ticket lift of Level 2 packaging alone adds \$42/order × 100-200 orders = \$4,200-8,400. This is pure margin.

Full dessert-table setup

The bigger presentation format — a full themed table of cookies at a wedding, baby shower or corporate event. Higher ticket, higher visibility.

A dessert-table order runs \$250-800 USD. Higher logistical complexity, higher visibility (photographed by attendees, wedding photographers, event coordinators) and higher referral output. Master this format once your production baseline is solid.

What goes on a dessert table (baseline setup)

- **3-4 tiered levels** using cake stands, wooden risers or acrylic pedestals
- **Colour-matched cookies** — the theme colours the customer specified for the event
- **Complementary components** — sometimes you supply just the cookies, sometimes you're providing macarons, cake pops, meringues to fill the table (or you subcontract with another baker)
- **Signage / labels** — small printed cards identifying flavours and allergens
- **On-site setup time** — usually 45-90 minutes at the venue before guest arrival

Pricing a dessert table

Two components:

1. Per-cookie price (usually 10-15% higher than a boxed order because of setup risk)
2. Setup fee: \$50-150 flat, covering delivery, on-site setup, styling and tear-down

A 50-cookie dessert table at \$8.50/cookie plus \$100 setup fee = \$525. A 100-cookie table at \$8/cookie plus \$150 = \$950. These are the ticket ranges you graduate to at month 6-12.

THE EVENT-PHOTOGRAPHER CONTACT

Every wedding or event has a professional photographer. At the setup, hand your card to the photographer and ask if they'd share the shots of your table when they're delivered to the client. About 60% will. This is the fastest way to build a portfolio of professionally photographed dessert tables — invaluable for landing more event work.

CLOSING

Your packaging upgrade this month

The five specific purchases that upgrade a Level 0 or Level 1 setup to Level 2 in one order.

One-time upgrade purchases (~\$120 USD total)

25x kraft boxes with clear window (8x8x2 in)	\$32
250x custom stickers with your logo (Vistaprint / Sticker Mule)	\$28
100x 4x6 in cellophane bags + impulse heat sealer	\$25
Ribbon assortment (5 colours, satin, 3/8 in)	\$14
Food-safe silica gel packets (100-pack)	\$12
Tissue paper crinkle-cut (assorted colours)	\$8
250x thank-you cards	\$12

This upgrade pays for itself in your next 3 orders. Every order after that is pure margin lift compared to Level 0. This is the fastest ROI in this entire program.

Same cookie. Bigger ticket.

Every hour you spend upgrading packaging returns 5-10× the equivalent hour spent baking more. Do the packaging upgrade first.

Next bonus to open

Now that the perceived value is set, open **Bonus 5 · Pricing That Profits** to make sure the numbers on your quotes actually turn into money in your account.